

API Key

Definition

An application programming interface (API) key is a secret unique identifier used to authenticate and authorize a user, developer, or calling program to an API.

Purpose

API keys serve as credentials that allow systems to verify the identity of the requester and ensure that only authorized parties can access specific resources or services through an API.

Best Practices

Cloud computing providers such as Google Cloud Platform and Amazon Web Services recommend that API keys only be used to authenticate projects, rather than human users. This approach enhances security by separating authentication from individual user identities.

Security Considerations

- API keys should be kept secret and not shared publicly
- They are typically used for programmatic access to services
- Proper management of API keys is crucial for maintaining system security